

Lesson 7: Different Strokes, Different Folks

Danni Varlan

Raise your hand if you know someone in your life who either communicates or receives communication differently than you do. We all do, right? Sometimes they live with us. Sometimes we're related to them. And sometimes we're raising them. And the workplace is no different.

When she was coaching her players, Pat famously said, "It's a question of personalities and finding the most effective language to use with a player." Some people you can rip their heads off and they still won't give you their full attention. Others will break at a single word. Do you know the personality types of those you work with? Could you guess? Take a minute after this video to jot down the names of your team members along with a simple word or tag beside their name:

- Extrovert
- Introvert
- Thinker
- Feeler

These four words go a long way in telling you how to communicate with others. But we often don't even slow down to think about it, much less the more detailed parts of each personality.

If you gave a personality test to each member of your team, chances are they would be unique flowers with different facets and elements to their personality. So you can't really walk around doing learning style tests with everybody you meet. But there are a few tips that you can use to sort of figure out what it might be. For example, do they like to learn through people and experience? Or do they like to learn through books and experts? And after they learn something, do they want to just go do it? Or do they want to think about it for a while and get it right in their head before they decide to start?

So how does that help you as a leader? Well, this carries over to how you as a leader choose to communicate in any given situation with a particular team member.

Take Tamara, an assertive go-getter. Let's say Tamara's driven, confident, and results-oriented. When communicating with someone like Tamara, be direct and concise. Respect her time and get to the point quickly. Emphasize facts and outcomes. She may appreciate evidence to support your ideas. Stay professional. Keep emotions in check and focus on the task at hand.

Now let's meet Mark, a friendly social butterfly. Mark is outgoing, extroverted, and loves to connect with others. When communicating with someone like Mark, engage in small talk. Take

a few minutes to ask about his weekend or hobbies. Slow down and be approachable. Be an active listener. Show interest in what he has to say and be sure you're practicing active listening.

Or Juan, the analytical perfectionist. Juan is detail-oriented, precise, and values accuracy. When communicating with someone like Juan, present data. Support your ideas with well-researched information. Be patient and open to questions. Juan may need time to process and seek clarity.

Do you have any people like this on your team? I bet you do. Another really good example is my husband and me. We are the total opposite. I am always ready to do something out, very, very social, and he is very quiet. He wants to know all of the details and he wants to think about it. And think about it. And think about it. Until he gets the right answer.

This information can be used anywhere. So, let's get started in learning how you can become a master in using different communication strokes for different folks.